the will to attempt to implement it. Undersourcing American commitments and failing to articulate a clear and credible strategy—re-creating the Lippmann Gap between ends and means—would be particularly dangerous in an environment where China is regularly testing US resolve. Instead, US interests will be best served by occupying a middle ground of being committed to maintaining the vast gains made in stability and prosperity while recognizing limitations on American power.

Since 1945, America's primary interest has been to maintain a balance of power in the Pacific and prevent the rise of an aggressive hegemon that would threaten its freedom and peace. This should remain Washington's top priority. China has every right to operate in international waters and protect its own national interests, but not at the expense of regional stability. The United States cannot intervene in every dispute between Beijing and its neighbors, but China equally cannot be allowed to unilaterally set maritime or aerospace rules of conduct or alter national boundaries, whether through intimidation or force. Rather than containing China at every turn, constraining its assertive and aggressive behavior when necessary should be America's goal.

A strategy to ensure this outcome rests on a continued forward-based US naval and air presence in the region, so as to make credible our promises to ensure freedom of navigation and defend our allies if need be. Washington should focus on countering and preventing any attempts to restrict freedom of navigation or to intimidate states from fully exercising their right to peaceful passage and transit on the high seas. American freedom of navigation operations should continue to be conducted regularly, as the Trump administration has begun doing—if possible, with regional partners. Attention should be paid above all to the East and South China Seas, the eastern Indian Ocean, and the vital waterways of the Malacca, Sunda, Taiwan, and Tsushima Straits. Washington should make further efforts to form maritime communities of interest that develop common operating procedures and cooperate more closely, particularly in crucial waterways. Greater joint training, military exercises, and sharing of sensitive information can help forge more capable and confident Asian defense forces and